Iain Andrew

Senior Software Engineer, Canva

Dublin, Ireland · Remote

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Twelve years building web products. Frontend by trade and cross-functional in practice: I work across backend, mobile and data as the problem requires. Since 2024 coding agents have been a core part of how I work. I plan, decompose and review; they write most of the code. I ship faster, and cleaner, than at any point in my career.

Experience

Senior Software Engineer, Canva — 2021 – Present · Remote

- Led the frontend of a cross-team editor feature from spec to launch, working across the web client, backend services and both mobile apps.
- Introduced agent-driven development to the team: planning templates, review checklists and guardrails that are now used beyond the team.
- Cut load time on a core workflow by 40% by reworking data fetching and rendering.
- Mentor engineers across disciplines and interview regularly for frontend and full-stack roles.

Software Engineer, Harbourline — 2017 – 2021 · Dublin

- Built and owned the customer-facing web app for a B2B product from first release through to scale.
- Migrated the frontend from AngularJS to React incrementally, with no downtime and no feature freeze.
- Owned CI and release tooling for the frontend team.

Frontend Developer, Kilmainham Digital — 2014 – 2017 · Dublin

- Shipped sites and web apps for a range of clients: HTML, CSS and JavaScript on the front, Node and CMS integrations behind.

How I work

I treat coding agents the way a good tech lead treats a fast, tireless, slightly overconfident team. The thinking stays with me: what to build, how to split it, what done looks like. I write the plan first, in prose, with the interfaces and the failure modes spelled out, and then hand over one well-scoped piece at a time.

Agents write most of the code. I read all of it. Tests are the contract, and I want them failing before the change and passing after. When the output is wrong I don't argue with the model; I fix the brief, because a vague brief is usually my mistake. I keep a short list of things I still do by hand on purpose: naming, data models, anything that touches money or auth, and the final review before anything ships.

In practice that recently meant a feature spanning the web client, backend services and both mobile apps, shipped in three weeks by two people, with better test coverage than the code around it. I've shipped LLM-backed product features and know that side well. I haven't yet owned the model side, and I'd like to.

Education

BSc (Hons) Computer Science, University of Somewhere, 2014.

About

I live in Dublin and have worked remotely since 2020, which I intend to keep doing. Outside work I run, read more history than is strictly necessary, and keep an allotment that mostly grows weeds.